

PHARMA

Shot at Weight Loss

Eli Lilly has launched weight-loss drug Mounjaro in India, priced at ₹3,500 per injection for a 2.5mg dose. Will high costs be a barrier to the reach?

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA



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► **WITH DIABETES AND** obesity cases surging in India, pharmaceutical giant Eli Lilly and Company (India) has launched Mounjaro (tirzepatide), a once-weekly injectable drug for chronic weight management and type 2 diabetes.

Approved by the Central Drugs Standard Control Organization (CDSCO), Mounjaro is the first dual-target therapy that activates both GIP (glucose-dependent insulinotropic polypeptide) and GLP-1 (glucagon-like peptide-1) receptors, helping regulate blood sugar levels while promoting weight loss. The

2.5 mg dose is priced at ₹3,500 per injection, with a monthly cost of ₹14,000, while the 5 mg dose is ₹4,375 per injection.

According to the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5) 2019-21, obesity is increasing, with 6.5% of Indian adults classified as obese. Unlike conventional diabetes and weight-loss drugs, Mounjaro works by enhancing insulin secretion, reducing glucagon production, slowing gastric emptying, and improving fat metabolism.

“The dual burden of obesity and type 2 diabetes is rapidly emerging

as a major public health challenge in India. Lilly is committed to collaborating with the government and industry to promote awareness and improve the prevention and management of these diseases,” said Winselow Tucker, President and General Manager, Eli Lilly India.

Lilly’s Mounjaro enters a growing weight-loss drug market in India, especially with the global success of GLP-1 receptor agonists like Novo Nordisk’s semaglutide (Wegovy, Ozempic). Industry analysts expect Indian pharmaceutical companies to introduce their own versions once patents expire.

Companies like Sun Pharmaceuticals, Cipla, Dr. Reddy’s Laboratories, and Lupin are already working on GLP-1-based therapies, preparing for increased demand once patents expire in 2026 in various global markets. Novo Nordisk, which dominates this segment, is expected to expand access and reduce prices to counter new competition, according to industry sources.

While Mounjaro offers a new approach to diabetes and obesity management, its cost could be a barrier, according to doctors. Tirzepatide, an injectable medication for weight loss and diabetes management, is seen as a major advancement, but its affordability remains a concern. “Its cost may limit access to a small group of patients. Wider availability could depend on future price adjustments or more affordable alternatives,” says Dr. Anoop Misra, Chairman, Fortis C-DOC Hospital for Diabetes and Allied Sciences.

While such medications are typically recommended for morbidly obese individuals, in India, film stars and affluent individuals are already using them. With more pharmaceutical companies entering the obesity and diabetes drug market, the coming years could bring greater price competition and improved accessibility. **BT**

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